▶ JAMMU AND KASHMIR

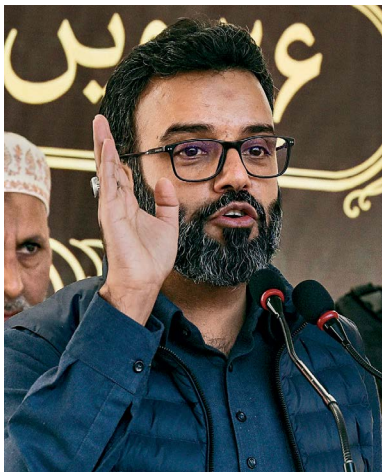
Ruhullah Speaks a Fiery Farewell

The NC suffers a shock as its sharpest internal critic calls it quits—citing its failure to redeem poll pledges

By **Ishfaq Tantry**

IN A SHARP BREAK WITH THE PARTY THAT SHAPED his career—but in line with his trenchant critique of the Omar Abdullah government of late—Srinagar MP Aga Syed Ruhullah Mehdi has finally made good on a long-standing threat. He quit the National Conference (NC) and quit his prestigious Lok Sabha seat on November 3. It was a significant day for the charismatic 50-year-old—the 26th death anniversary of his father, late Congress leader and Shia cleric Aga Syed Mehdi. His assassination in 2000, in an IED blast, had marked the moment when Ruhullah had entered politics—at the invitation of Omar's father, Farooq Abdullah, who was then CM.

Announcing the step at Behishti Zehra Park in his native Budgam took him back to those roots in central Kashmir, from where he eventually carved out a space for himself as an articulate mass leader, a favourite campaigner across the Valley during the LS elections of 2024. The system shock his exit produces to the party is proportionate to that star value.



ANI

Takeaways

- **Ruhullah Mehdi quits NC, Srinagar MP seat in protest**
- **Accuses Omar of failing to restore J&K's honour, status**

GRAVE CHARGES

Add the cause, and the discomfiture is even more acute for Omar. Ruhullah is accusing the NC leadership of betrayal and abandoning its electoral promises: restoration of Article 370, release of prisoners and protection of J&K's constitutional rights. Amid charged sloganeering, the four-time legislator launched a scathing attack on the Abdullahs, accusing them of a sellout on Kashmir, appeasement of the BJP, and staying in a passive zone of "comfortable politics". He ended dramatically, waving his resignation letter and saying: "I am signing the document of my freedom."

Analysts are watching his moves on a promised alternate setup. "Only a local forum reflecting the dominant sentiment can ensure his survival," says academic Sheikh Showkat Hussain. "If he joins mainstream parties, he may lose from Srinagar as well." The scepticism extends to the 20-odd MLAs who dissented after Omar's October 27 cabinet expansion, given their system entrenchment.

That doesn't ease the NC's angst. It's facing one of its gravest ruptures since returning to power in a Union territory setup—also an outcome of New Delhi's go-slow on statehood. ■

By **Jumana Shah**

A CCTV AT A RESIDENTIAL SOCIETY suddenly catches sight of a leopard: it's coolly climbing into Serendeep Mansions, a gated community on VIP Road in Ghuma. Days later, a cafe owner claims a sighting in Zundal. Then another, in Chandkheda, 25 kilometres away. Forest teams go on the hunt with thermal cameras and drones, unsure if they are tracking one animal or several. Ahmedabad's residents, who may have happily spent money for a leopard sighting in a sanctuary, find it hard to quell the tremors at the thought of an unwelcome bounty in the neighbourhood. After one spotted autumn in the city, urban planners fret over the map.

Why are leopards moving to the city? For the same reason as people: food. Stray dogs are relatively easy prey, and the scrub and farmland on the city offer plenty residential options. That's logical, but invert it and it's still logical. It's the city that has come to the leopard, predating upon its space. Those scrub forests were their natural habitat not too long ago, part of Gujarat's wildlife corridor continuum. Now, a range of posh bungalows have invaded those zones, followed by noisy shopping centres, wide roads and restaurants.

DEVOURING COUNTRY

Every city expands. The issue is, 90 per cent of this is unplanned, haphazard. Which means no thought given to integrating within it spatial reservoirs for the natural lifeworlds it is eating up. Result: a cancerous growth of 'contiguous built-up area'. Landsat imagery shows Ahmedabad's has more than doubled in three decades. It was 132 sq. km in 1990, it touched 305 sq. km by 2019; researchers project another quarter by 2030. That's 18-20 sq. km of leopard country devoured each year. Delhi expands 50 sq. km every year, adding one central Paris every two